



Screening for Prenatal Alcohol Exposure

PAE is common and often unrecognized. It can present as ADHD, anxiety, oppositional behavior, or a learning disability, so screening for it early gives every assessment that follows a more accurate frame.

Where to get the screening questions: Step 2 of the [Brain-Based Treatment Builder](#) walks you through PAE/FASD screening with stigma-reducing language, matched to who you're talking with.

Assessing for Brain Function

Traditional mental health assessments often overlook brain function. Brain-based clinicians integrate IEPs, neuropsych, and OT/PT/SLP evaluations into treatment planning and connect results to behavioral support strategies.

Prior to Initial Assessment

Category	What to Request
Developmental & therapy evaluations	Neuropsychological, Occupational Therapy, and Speech-Language evaluations and treatment plans; previous school evaluations and IEP
Mental health & medical history	Previous mental health evaluations and treatment plans; medical and medication records
Client/caregiver interview	Prenatal and birth history, including screening for prenatal alcohol exposure (PAE), prenatal drug exposure (PDE), or other potential factors

Common Evidence-Based Assessments for Brain-Based Challenges

Primary Characteristic	Evidence-Based Assessment	Age Range	Who Can Administer / Where to Find Results
Memory	Children's Memory Scale · WRAML-2	5–90	Neuropsychology or School Psychology report
Development	Bayley Scale of Infant Development (4th ed.) · Vineland Adaptive Behavior Scale	Birth–90	Masters-level professional (psychology, education, or social work)
Sensory Issues	Sensory Profile	Infant–14 years	Caregivers/teachers (rating forms) / Occupational Therapist
Processing Speed & Thought Process	WPPSI · WISC · WAIS · IQ Tests	2.6–90 years	Psychologists / Psychological & School Psychological reports
Speech/Language	CASL-2	3–21 years	Speech-Language Pathologist / Speech and Language Evaluations
Auditory Processing	SCAN · dichotic listening · speech-in-noise	Varies	Speech-Language Therapists / Audiologists / their reports
Learning Style	VARK Assessment · observation during play & daily activities	Varies	Self-administered (12+) or caregivers/teachers (under 12)
Behavioral Functioning	BASC-3 · BRIEF	2–21	Psychologists, trained individuals (teacher/parent forms)
Attention/Executive Functioning	Conners Comprehensive Rating Scales	2–18	Trained professionals, teachers, parent rating forms
Trauma	CATS (Child and Adolescent Trauma Screen)	3–17	Caregiver & self-report

What If There's No Formal Testing?

A neuropsychological evaluation is the gold standard, but it isn't always available. Step 4 of our [Brain-Based Treatment Builder](#) builds a brain-function profile from direct observation; Vanessa Spiller's Ability Wheel and the FASCETS Neurobehavioral Exploration Tool (FASCETS training required) are alternatives. Refer out if needs exceed your scope.

Other Considerations

- Assess the cognitive capacity and learning style of the support system (parent/caregiver/support person)
- Assess the level of stressors within the environment and support system
- Identify available resources and services for both the client and their support system

Treat the Brain You're With



Brain-Based Mental Health

A FASD United Mental Health Work Group project



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